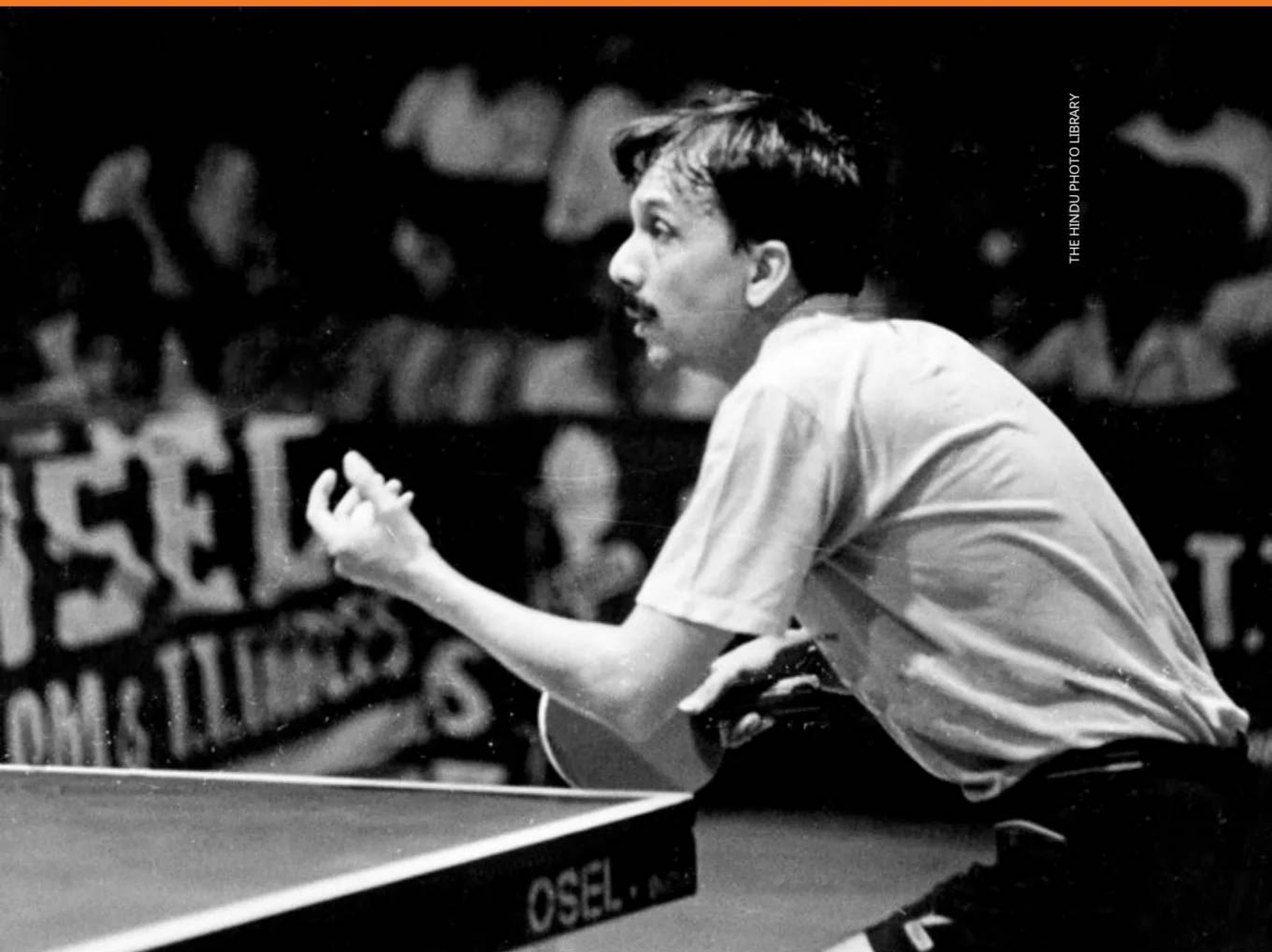




There was a huge change in the format. From eight players in a group in Seoul, it had been shrunk to four players in a group for the league stage, with only the group-topper progressing to the knockouts. I had Lu Lin — the multiple times Chinese national champion — in my group who was billed as China's future star and Kim Taek-Su, the Korean legend along with a Latin American paddler.

It was a tough group and the very first match was against Lu Lin. I had competed against him in the qualification event knockouts and I thought I played my best table tennis, but was still nowhere close to stretching him. I lost convincingly in the qualifiers despite being at my best but in Barcelona, the tide had turned. Having played against him

not long ago, I could plan a strategy along with coach Manjit Dua and the Chinese coach Lid Yang. I knew I had to remain at my peak and catch him off guard. The match was early in the morning and just like in Hong Kong, it ended in straight games. In my favour, though!

I had opened up a decisive 15-5 lead. He covered up quite a bit in the second game but the last service was in my hand at 20-15. He was attacking everything that was coming his way, so I literally served a simple service — a beginner's service — and he hit it too hard and it went long. It resulted in a window of silence in the hall. I had beaten Lu Lin! A Chinese had lost a match in the Olympics, that too in the league stage. And I was the conqueror. I then beat the Latin American and

lost to Kim Taek-Su despite stretching him to the decider. Had Lu Lin overcome Kim Taek-Su, it would have been a triple tie between us but Kim Taek-Su was on song. Not only did he beat Lu Lin but also went on to earn the bronze medal. I may not have qualified for the knockouts, we were not really medal prospects but I definitely had one of the highlights of my career at the Olympics. Lu Lin was a member of the gold-medal winning pair in men's doubles in Barcelona and I had knocked him out!

I couldn't stay back to watch other top stars in action as my wife Monalisa was due to deliver our second child, so there was an important medal waiting for me back home!

**As told to Amol Karhadkar**